

Session 21: The House on the Rock

Key Takeaways

- The rain and flood are strongly established biblical themes representing the moment in the cyclical pattern when God's judgment de-creates the status quo in order to bring about new creation.
- The house on the rock is a stock biblical image for the temple in Jerusalem. Jesus links the people of God's Kingdom to a house God is building on a rock, which can withstand the coming flood.
- Biblical apocalyptic literature teaches us to view the world through the lens of a recurring cycle of themes, ultimately pointing to the final purpose toward which God is steering all creation.

Two Houses

A 24 So then, **everyone who hears these words of mine**,
and does them,
they will be like a wise man,
who built his house on the rock,

B 25 **and the rain came down,**
and the rivers came,
and the winds blew,
and they fell upon that house,

C but it did not fall,
because its foundation was on the rock.

A' 26 And **everyone who hears these words of mine**,
and does not do them,
they will be like a foolish man,
who built his house on the sand,

B' 27 **and the rain came down,
and the rivers came,
and the winds blew,
and they fell upon that house,**

C' and it fell,
and its falling was huge.

Matthew 7:24-27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

The rhetorical design of this final warning is easy to discern. The two builders are compared and contrasted in obvious ways:

- Doing the words vs. not doing the words
- Wise vs. foolish
- House on the rock vs. house on the sand
- House doesn't fall vs. house does fall

Moses, Lady Wisdom, and Jesus

Notice that this final unit is all about how one responds to the words of Jesus. This feels similar to the conclusion of the Torah, which focuses on the final words of Moses and makes Israel's response to them determinative for their future destiny.

Deuteronomy 32:1-2 NASB

Give ear, O heavens, and **let me speak;**
and let the earth hear **the words of my mouth.**
Let **my teaching** drop as the rain,
my speech distill as the dew,
as the droplets on the fresh grass
and as the showers on the herb.

Deuteronomy 32:5-6 NASB

They have acted corruptly toward him,
they are not his children, because of their defect;
but are a perverse and crooked generation.
Do you thus repay the LORD, **O foolish and unwise people?**
Is not he your Father who has bought you?
He has made you and established you.

Deuteronomy 32:28-30 NASB

For they are a nation **lacking in counsel,**
and there is no understanding in them.

Would that they were wise, that they **understood this**,
that they would **discern** their future!
How could one chase a thousand,
and two put ten thousand to flight,
unless their Rock had sold them,
and the LORD had given them up?

Wise or Foolish

“Foolish” here is the Greek *moros* / *μωρός*, from which we get the English word “moron.”

Jesus first used this word in a subtle wordplay on the “salt of the land” metaphor at the opening of the sermon. In this way, Matthew ensures that the motif of “wisdom/folly” appears at the bookends of the sermon.

Matthew 5:13 Instructor's Translation

But if the salt becomes **foolish** (*moranthe*), it is good for nothing.

By using “wisdom/folly” vocabulary, Jesus also activates the scriptural wisdom traditions, placing himself in the role of Lady Wisdom from [Proverbs 1-9](#).

Proverbs 1:20-22, 24-27 NASB

²⁰ **Wisdom** shouts in the street,
she lifts her voice in the square;
²¹ at the head of the noisy streets she cries out;
at the entrance of the gates in the city she utters her sayings:
²² “How long, O naive ones, will you love being simple-minded?
And scoffers delight themselves in scoffing and fools hate knowledge?
²⁴ Because I called and you refused, I stretched out my hand and no one paid attention;
²⁵ and **you neglected all my counsel and did not want my reproof**;
²⁶ I will also laugh at your calamity; I will mock when your dread comes,
²⁷ **when your dread comes like a storm
and your calamity comes like a whirlwind,
when distress and anguish come upon you.**”

Also important is the echo of the “city on the mountain” and the “light of the world” images from the sermon’s introduction. These come from Isaiah and other prophetic traditions about the pilgrimage of the nations.

Isaiah 2:1-2 NASB

The word which Isaiah the son of Amoz saw concerning Judah and Jerusalem.
Now it will come about that in the last days
the mountain of the house of the LORD
will be established as the chief of the **mountains**,
and will be raised above the hills;
and all the nations will stream to it.

So here, at the matching bookend of the sermon, we find the language of the “house” on the “rock,” which are core scriptural images for Mount Zion and the temple. The “flood/storm” images are stock images in the prophets for attacking foreign nations.

Isaiah 8:7-8 NASB

Now therefore, behold, the Lord is about **to bring on them the strong and abundant waters of the Euphrates,**
even the king of Assyria and all his glory;
and it will rise up over all its channels and go over all its banks.

Then it will sweep on into Judah, **it will overflow and pass through,** it will reach even to the neck;
and the spread of its wings will fill the breadth of your land, O Immanuel.

Isaiah 28:16-17 NASB

Therefore thus says the Lord God,
“Behold, I am laying **in Zion a stone,** a tested **stone,**
a costly cornerstone **for the foundation,** firmly placed.
He who believes in it will not be disturbed.
I will make justice the measuring line
and righteousness the level;
then hail will sweep away the refuge of lies
and the waters will overflow the secret place.”

Jeremiah 6:22-23 NASB

Thus says the LORD,
“Behold, **a people is coming from the north land,**
and a great nation will be aroused from the remote parts of the earth.
They seize bow and spear;
they are cruel and have no mercy;
their voice roars like the sea,
and they ride on horses, arrayed as a man for the battle
against you, O daughter of Zion!”

Ezekiel 13:10-14 NASB

¹⁰ It is definitely because [the false prophets] have misled my people by saying, “Peace!” when there is no peace. And when anyone **builds a wall,** behold, they plaster it over with whitewash;

¹¹ so tell those who plaster it over with whitewash, that it will fall. A flooding rain will come, and you, O hailstones, will fall; and a violent wind will break out.

¹² Behold, when the wall has fallen, will you not be asked, “Where is the plaster with which you plastered it?”

¹³ Therefore, thus says the Lord God, “I will make a violent wind break out in my anger. There will also be in my anger a flooding rain and hailstones to consume it in anger.

¹⁴ So I will tear down the wall which you plastered over with whitewash and bring it down to the ground, so that its **foundation** is laid bare; and **when it falls,** you will be consumed in its midst. And you will know that I am the LORD.

Psalm 48:1-8 NASB

¹ Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised,
in the city of our God, his holy mountain.
² Beautiful in elevation, the joy of the whole earth,
is **Mount Zion** in the far north,
the city of the great King.
³ God, in her palaces,
has made himself known as a stronghold.
⁴ For, lo, the kings assembled themselves,
they passed by together.
⁵ They saw it, then they were **shocked**;
they were terrified, they fled in alarm.
⁶ Panic seized them there,
anguish, as of a woman in childbirth.
⁷ **With the east wind**
you break the ships of Tarshish.
⁸ As we have heard, so have we seen
in the city of the LORD of hosts, in the city of our God;
God will establish her forever. Selah.

Joel 2:1-2 NASB

Blow a trumpet in **Zion**,
and sound an alarm on **my holy mountain!**
Let all the inhabitants of the land tremble,
for **the day of the LORD is coming**;
surely it is near,
a day of **darkness** and **gloom**,
a day of **clouds** and **thick darkness**.
As the dawn is spread over the mountains,
so there **is a great and mighty people**;
there has never been anything like it,
nor will there be again after it
to the years of many generations.

Joel 2:32 NASB

And it will come about that **whoever calls on the name of the LORD**
will be delivered;
for **on Mount Zion and in Jerusalem**
there will be those who escape,
as the LORD has said,
even among the survivors whom the LORD calls.

Jesus will later compare the downfall of the Jerusalem temple to a coming storm like the flood.

Matthew 24:1-2 NASB

Jesus came out from the temple and was going away when his disciples came up to point out the temple buildings to him. And he said to them, "Do you not see all these things? Truly I say to you, **not one stone here will be left upon another, which will not be torn down.**"

Matthew 24:37-39 NASB

For the coming of the Son of Man will be **just like the days of Noah**. For as in those days before the flood they were eating and drinking, marrying and giving in marriage, until the day that Noah entered the ark, and they did not understand until the flood came and took them all away; so will the coming of the Son of Man be.

In Luke's version of this same speech, Jesus explicitly brings up the cosmic storm imagery to describe the downfall of Jerusalem.

Luke 21:20-26 NASB

²⁰ But **when you see Jerusalem surrounded by armies**, then recognize that her desolation is near. ²¹ Then those who are in Judea must flee to the mountains, and those who are in the midst of the city must leave, and those who are in the country must not enter the city; ²² because these are days of vengeance, so that all things which are written will be fulfilled. ²³ Woe to those who are pregnant and to those who are nursing babies in those days; for there will be great distress upon the land and wrath to this people; ²⁴ and they will fall by the edge of the sword, and will be led captive into all the nations; and Jerusalem will be trampled under foot by the Gentiles until the times of the Gentiles are fulfilled.

²⁵ There will be signs in sun and moon and stars, and on the earth dismay among nations, in perplexity at the **roaring of the sea and the waves**, ²⁶ men fainting from fear and the expectation of the things which are coming upon the world; for the powers of the heavens will be shaken.

"Consider [the parable of the house of the rock], for example, remembering that, within his culture, the word 'house' could easily evoke the idea of 'Temple', and that the 'rock' or 'stone' would readily be identified as the foundation-stone of that Temple. ... Jesus, like some other Jewish sectarians, was inviting his hearers to join him in the establishment of the true Temple. The Jerusalem Temple was under judgment, a judgment that would fall before too long. The demons, as we saw, would return, and the last state of the 'house' would be worse than the first. Falling masonry, as when the tower of Siloam fell, will be the fate of the unrepentant. The 'house' is left, abandoned, desolate, unprotected against enemy attack. It is in this context that Jesus' dramatic action in the Temple makes perfect sense: it was an acted parable of judgment, of destruction."

Wright, N. T. (1997). [*Jesus and the Victory of God*](#). Fortress Press. 334.

In his Jewish context, this reflected the high estimation Jesus has of his words and authority. By contrast, similar parables were often told about how Israel responds to the words of the Torah.

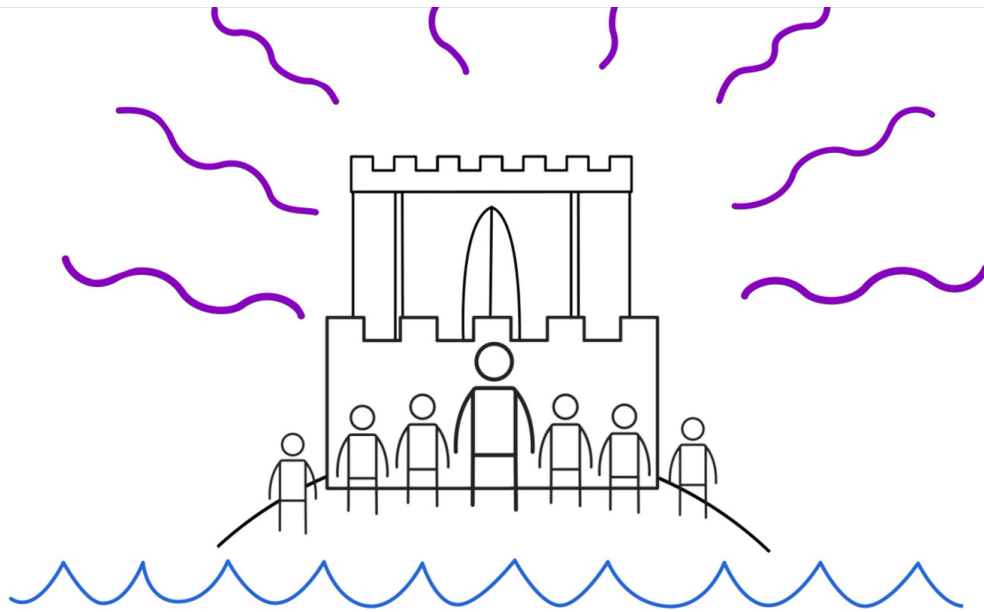
'Avot de Rabbi Nathan ch. 24 (appendix to the Babylonian Talmud):

Elisha b. Abbuyah (ca. 120 AD) said, "A person who has many good works and has studied much Torah, to what can he be compared? To a person who builds with stones at the foundation and then with bricks (unbaked, only dried in the sun); even if many waters come and remain on their sides, they do not dissolve

the solid stones from their place. But a person who has no good works and studies Torah, to what can he be compared? To a person who builds first with bricks and then with stones; even if only small amounts of water come, they topple them immediately.”

Strack, Hermann L. & Billerbeck, Paul (2022). [*A Commentary on the New Testament from the Talmud & Midrash*](#). Lexham Press. 525.

The Servant and the Coming Flood



The Servant and the Coming Flood. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Reflection Question

How is Jesus’ parable of the house in the rain connected to themes from the Hebrew Bible?

Session 22: Reflecting on Jesus' Teaching

Key Takeaways

- Matthew highlights the response of the crowd, inviting us to examine our own response and reflect on the words we just heard.
- The astonishing authority of Jesus is a thread that runs throughout the book of Matthew.
- Jesus' teaching is not simplistic, and it invites us into a lifetime of meditation.
- Studying Scripture in community is transformative. Sharing in the perspectives of others builds us up as the Bible invites all of us to be people of God's Kingdom.

Jesus Teaches With Authority

Matthew 7:28-29 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus finished these words, the crowds were astonished at his teaching, because he was teaching as one having authority, and not like their scribes.

It Is Finished ... For Now

This is the first of five coordinated conclusions throughout the main body of Matthew's account of Jesus. Each one has been modeled after the conclusion of Moses' main speeches in Deuteronomy, and is part of a larger strategy to portray Jesus as Israel's messianic greater-than-Moses. But the conclusion to Matthew 5-7 is unique among these five conclusions, as it is the only one that does not immediately transition into the next story.

Matthew 7:28 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) these words, the crowds were astonished ...

Matthew 11:1-2 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when he **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) instructing his twelve apprentices, he moved on from there, to teach and to announce in their cities, and Ioannes, having heard in prison about the works of the Messiah ...

Matthew 13:53-54 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) these parables, he went away from there, and having gone to his homeland, he was teaching them in their synagogue,

Matthew 19:1-2 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) these words, he went away from Galilaia, and he went into the regions of Ioudaia, beyond the Iordanes, and many crowds followed him, and he healed them there;

Matthew 26:1-2 Instructor's Translation

And it came about when Jesus **finished** (ἐτέλεσεν) all these words, he said to his apprentices, "You know that Paskha happens after two days, and the son of the human is to be handed over to be crucified."

"Despite the significant parallels with the conclusions to the other major discourses, 7:28–9 stands out as atypical. This is because it is the only conclusion which does not carry the story forward. 11:1; 13:54; 19:1; and 26:1 all immediately immerse the reader back into the narrative flow. Only after the sermon on the mount is there a pause in which to catch one's breath. This circumstance undoubtedly advertises the uniqueness of 5–7 for the evangelist's work. Matthew's readers are expected to stop and ponder what has been said; they are to realize, however dimly, that the great sermon hides a multitude of profound ramifications and that it is accordingly something to be returned to again and again."

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [*Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)*](#). T&T Clark International. 725.

Teaching With Authority

Matthew registers the powerful effect Jesus' teaching had on the (mainly) Israelite crowds who heard his teaching. There is a contrast with the kind of Torah-teaching they normally hear. Matthew does not tell us what exactly they heard that struck them in a new way, but he links it to the word "authority" (Greek: *exousia* / ἐξουσία).

With this word, Matthew begins a golden thread throughout his account, which will portray Jesus as having a unique, divine authority as he challenges Israel's leaders. It is also related to the word "permitted" or, more literally, "authorized," (Greek: *exestin* / ἐξεστιν).

Matthew 9:6-8 LEB

"But in order that you may know that **the Son of Man has authority on earth** to forgive sins," then he said to the paralytic, "Get up, pick up your stretcher and go to your home." And he got up and went to his home. But when the crowds saw this, they were afraid and glorified God who had given such **authority** to humans.

Matthew 10:1 LEB

And summoning his twelve disciples, he gave them **authority** over unclean spirits, so that they could expel them and could heal every disease and every sickness.

Matthew 12:2-4 Instructor's Translation

But when the Pharisees saw it, they said to him, "Behold, your disciples are doing what it is not **authorized** to do on the Sabbath!" So he said to them, "Have you not read what David did when he was hungry, and

those with him, how he entered into the house of God and ate the bread of the presentation, which it was not **authorized** for him or for those with him to eat, but only for the priests?

Matthew 21:23 LEB

And after he arrived at the temple, the chief priests and the elders of the people came up to him while he was teaching, saying, “By what **authority** are you doing these things? And who gave you this **authority**?”

Matthew 28:18 LEB

And Jesus approached and spoke to them, saying, “All **authority** in heaven and on earth has been given to me.”

There is another layer to this comment, however. In 1st century Jewish culture, where Torah-teaching was very much a communal and multi-generational endeavor, novelty was not a virtue when it came to teaching Torah in Israel. Rather, the legitimacy of a rabbi's teaching was shown by the lineage of ideas from teacher to student, as embodied in the famous saying about one of the most influential rabbis of the 1st century:

Pesakhim 6:1:33a The Jerusalem Talmud

“Rabbi Hillel lectured on the matter all day long, but they did not receive his teaching until he said, ‘Thus I heard from Shemaiah and Abtalion.’”

“Whereas scribal rulings were based on the tradition of earlier interpreters of the law, Jesus has in 5:17–48 set himself up as an authority over against that interpretive tradition, on the basis not of a formal training or authorization but of his own confident, ‘I tell you.’ It was that sort of inherent ‘authority’ that the people missed in their scribes, even though their office commanded respect. When to that remarkable claim is added Jesus’ assumption that he himself is the proper object of people’s allegiance and the arbiter of their destiny (5:11–12; 7:21–23, 24, 26), the crowd’s astonishment is hardly out of place.”

France, R. T. (2007). [*The Gospel of Matthew \(The New International Commentary on the New Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans. 299.

Reflection Question

Take some time to reflect on the insights you learned in this class.